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Playback's a Bitch

ReplayTV is more confusing than entertaining

By Mike Talon



You're in the middle of watching *the* game of the year, and your team is headed downfield for the winning touchdown, when suddenly...*Heidi* comes on? Okay, maybe not, but perhaps the doorbell rings. With ReplayTV, you can pause the action, lose the Jehovah's Witnesses and pick up right where you left off. We decided to put ReplayTV through the ROUZE Challenge to see how it performed.

What it is

About the size of a VCR, ReplayTV allows you to pause live TV events, then continue where you left off. It does so by recording from the moment you pause the action, then playing it back while it continues recording in the background. The unit sells for around $500, and is available online and in many retail stores.

What they say it does

ReplayTV can not only pause live events, but can also record your favorite shows without videotapes (up to 20 hours at a time) and even skip ahead in 30-second increments to jump over commercials. It can be set on a timer or on demand by finding the show you want in the built-in channel and show guide. And there are no monthly fees for any of the services.

The ROUZE challenge

We put ReplayTV through its paces in a normal home environment and immediately started running into problems. The instructions were difficult to understand, and the device itself was downright confusing. So we threw our top geek at it and quickly found out why we were having so much trouble—it doesn't use common cables to connect.

While you can plug the round wire from your cable box into the back of the unit, you must use either outdated wiring or cutting-edge technology to connect the device to your TV, not the round wire we're all used to.

We were eventually able to figure out the hieroglyphics on the poster-sized "quick-start" guide and get the thing hooked up. From that point on, it performed well. We were able to get most of the unit's major features to work, but not without a great deal of staring at the "simplified" remote control and wondering which button to press. We were eventually able to record a program, and to pause a live television show and pick it up a few minutes later.

The end result

Aside from the ability to pause a live broadcast, ReplayTV does little more than your average VCR with VCRplus. The VCR also has the advantage of tapes that can be stored, so you don't have to tape over stuff when you reach your storage limit. All things considered, we'd forego the high price tag, extremely difficult instructions and overall headaches, and go with a good old-fashioned VCR. As for the Jehovah's Witness, get a door-cam so you can ignore him and keep watching the game.

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